



Social Media Best Practice Guide

search engine **people**
get **found!**[™]



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A Guide to Best Practices



Why should your business be on Facebook?

Facebook is the fastest growing social media platform to date.

With over **1 Billion users**, Facebook provides businesses with endless opportunities to connect and engage with customers by promoting content, products and services.



When should you post?

Brands that post outside of business hours have been found to have **20% higher engagement rates** than average. Engagement varies by industry, so it's helpful if you can monitor your analytics (use FB Insights, Google Analytics, or Hub Spot). Generally, the less people are at work, the more they are on FB. Use pre-scheduled posts during the early mornings, early evenings, and late nights to promote optimal user-reach. Engagement rates are also **18% higher on Thursday and Friday** than other days of the week.ⁱ

How often should you post?

FB's algorithm, Edgerank, determines what items appear in a user's News Feed based on affinity (the relationship between the user and where the news came from), weight (i.e a video upload vs. a comment) and time (how recently something was posted). Posting every few hours should keep you in the feed.



What should you post?

Post content relevant to your business. Post links to your company's blog posts, promotions, articles, press releases, positive customer reviews, and industry-wide articles and news. FB's Timeline places a greater emphasis on images and videos now than the former profile page. Posting images and embedding videos on your timeline will help to increase your presence in the News Feed and subsequent engagement from your visitors.ⁱⁱ Keep things simple. Research shows that keeping your posts **80 characters or less** can result in a **27% higher engagement rate**.ⁱⁱⁱ Ask your visitors to "like" a link or "post" their comments, questions or concerns.

Tools to help



Izzui is a free FB app that promotes businesses to learn and share by creating material targeted to FB visitors who are interested in the content.



Scheduling Tools like **HootSuite** allow for automated posts to post content at your preferred time.



Wisdom is a free analytics app for FB that can provide businesses with insightful analytics (i.e. demographics) of their social networks –helpful when deciding who to target for FB ads

Tips for success

- Cover photo dimensions are 851x315 pixels, and can't include: price info, contact info, references to FB features or actions, or calls-to-actions. It's not an ad, but it should reflect your brand and grasp the visitor's attention
- Highlight certain posts (like promotions) by selecting "highlight on timeline" in your Activity Log, or chose "pin to top" of your FB page
- Be bold. Get to know what your audience likes by posting different content types or questions, see how they perform, and go from there!

i. / iii. <http://forms.buddymedia.com/rs/buddymedia/images/review-strategies-for-effective-facebook-wall-posts.pdf>

i. <http://www.insidefacebook.com/2011/12/27/edgerank-and-graph-rank-defined/>

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Glossary

People talking about this

the number of unique users who created a story about your page or post. Stories can include: likes, comments or shares of the post or page, answers to questions, responses to an event, mentions, tags, check-ins or recommendations.

Event

a feature that enables the organization of gatherings. Users can respond to an invitation via Facebook.

Groups

closed circles of people that share content and keep in touch on Facebook.

Likes

similar to favouriting a tweet, you can select the “like” button on Facebook to connect with things you care about (i.e. pictures, posts, pages).

Messages

a central place to exchange private messages, chats, emails and mobile texts with friends.

Notifications

email, onsite, or mobile updates about activity on Facebook.

Networks

affiliations with schools, locations or workplaces that you belong to.

Pages

Facebook pages allow businesses, brands and celebrities to connect with people on Facebook. Admins can post information and news feed updates to people who like their pages.

Privacy Settings

manage who can send you friend requests, messages, see your pictures, and more.

Timeline

your timeline, or Facebook profile, is your collection of the photos, stories, and experiences that tell your life story.

News Feed

your news feed is the ongoing list of updates on your home page that shows you what's new with the friends and pages you follow.

Lists

used to organize your friends. Similar to circles on Google+, lists allow you to segment your Facebook friends and choose to share your updates with certain lists.

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Why should your business be on Google+?

Google+ attracted over **100,000,000 users** within the first 6 months of launch. With advanced targeting options and a rapidly growing user base, Google+ provides businesses, decision makers and marketers alike with a number of advantages.

The benefit: Content posted to Google+ will appear in the natural search results on Google.com. If you're searching for a product, you will be able to see in the search results how many people have +1'd it, including any friends in your Google+ circles, making search results more personal and relevant, hopefully resulting in more qualified traffic to the respective site.

The caveat: despite significant growth, users spent a mere average of 3.3 minutes on the platform in January!
63% of Google+ users are men with a tendency to post about technology; **college students** and **software developers** comprise two of the biggest user groups on Google+.



When should you post?

Brands that post outside of business hours on other social media platforms have been found to have **20% higher engagement rates than average**.ⁱ Since Google+ is known for its techy group of users, post at lunch time when professionals are checking up on social platforms.



What should you post?

Grouping your followers into distinct "circles" and showing the content you post to a specific circle is likely to result in higher click-through rates and more engagement from those followers. Post your businesses updates, new products or services, blog posts, industry-related news or articles, promotions, or career postings. Particularly if you are in a technology-related vertical, having a Google+ presence could increase awareness of your brand among decision makers. Post images and videos related to your brand to keep your followers engaged.

Tools to help

Google+Timing

Google+Timing analyzes the history of your previous posts to determine your best day and hour to post content to Google+.



Google Insights for Search and **Google Trends** are free tools that can provide insight into what terms people are searching for or what's trending now. This can help you when determining what relevant keywords to include in your content on Google+ in order to show on the SERP for related search queries.

Tips for success

- Adding the +1 button across your site generates **3.5x more visits** to your Google+ page than sites without the button.ⁱⁱ
- It's easy to share content on Google+. Simply drag, drop, and share from your desktop!
- Since Google+ integrates content into Google's natural organic results, make sure to maintain best SEO practices while writing content on your Google+ page (e.g. make sure your keywords are located near your title and being used appropriately in the body).

i. <http://www.emarketer.com/Article.aspx?R=1008976>

ii. <http://forms.buddymedia.com/rs/buddymedia/images/review-strategies-for-effective-facebook-wall-posts.pdf>

iii. <http://blog.hubspot.com/blog/tabid/6307/bid/32115/Pinterest-vs-Google-Which-New-Social-Network-Is-Worth-Marketers-Time.aspx>

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Circles

Circles are groupings of those you are following on Google+. For example, you could create an “Industry” circle and choose to share content with those who you’ve categorized as other professionals in your industry.

Hangout

a Google+ hangout is an organized video conference using a webcam where you can chat with up to nine people at once.

Home

real-time posts from the users you follow in chronological order.

Posts

Similar to Facebook, a post is something you’ve chosen to share with your circles on Google+. As long as they’ve added you back to one of their circles, they will see your posted content.

Explore

create an event and invitation. Change permission settings to allow guests to share photos to the event easily and in real time from a desktop or phone.

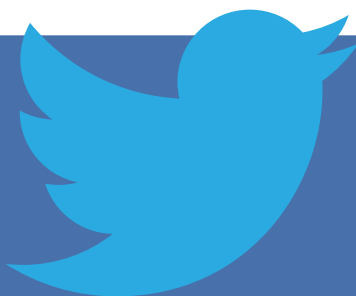
+1's

things that you have seen around the web that you like or want to recommend to others. Many websites will have the +1 social sharing button installed on content-rich pages, so if you’re signed into Google+ just click +1 and share that content with your preferred circles.

Local

under the local tab, view recommended places (i.e. restaurants, cafes, hotels) near your locations based on businesses’ Google+ Local profiles. View places by top reviewers or by ratings from people in your circles.

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Why should your business be on twitter?

Twitter is a major social platform where users can connect with their interests to share and learn information.

With over **140,000,000 active users** producing **340,000,000 tweets** a day, businesses can reach interested users and provide them with the most up-to-date insight into what's going on, right now. Use twitter to find out what people are saying about your business, your competitors, and your industry.

Tips for success

- Use paid promotion to gain and target your followers. Your twitter account will appear in the "who to follow" section for users with interests in line with your account. Use promoted tweets to target specific users, mobile devices, and search results. Your account's promoted tweet targeted to search terms will appear at the top of the search results page. **More info here:** <https://business.twitter.com/en/advertise/start/>
- Branding tip: add your company's logo to the 835x90 header now available on Twitter profiles.
- Increase engagement by: including links, hashtags (1 or 2), images, and asking your followers to "Retweet"
- Keep it simple. Research has shown that people respond better to plain and simple tweets rather than fluffed-up language.ⁱⁱⁱ

i. / ii. http://forms.buddymedia.com/whitepaper-form_strategies-for-effective-tweeting.html

iii. <http://mashable.com/2012/06/26/marketers-failing-twitter-study/>



When should you post?

Twitter engagement rates for brands have been found to be **17% higher on Saturday and Sunday** compared to weekdays. Other peak tweet times are noon and after work hours (5 and 6pm).ⁱ

How often should you post?

It has been found that **4 tweets per day** is an effective number of tweets, after which engagement significantly decreases.ⁱⁱ Also, Tweeting randomly or sporadically may make you seem spam-like. Tweet regularly and at consistent time intervals to ensure your brand's credibility.



What should you post?

Share what your company is doing right now. Tweet your promotions and new or upcoming products. Retweet and respond to positive customer reviews (thank them for making you look good!), and respond to customer inquiries. Tweet industry-related articles and news to keep your followers engaged. You want to become a resource of interesting and useful updates, providing Value to your customers.

Tools to help



Monitter is a real time search tool where you can track your industry, brand, or relevant keywords simultaneously and by demographic, allowing for better targeted tweets and increased presence on the search results page.



Hootsuite is a free social media dashboard that will tell you directly when your target audience is most active, track your brand's mentions, schedule messages and tweets, and more.



Klout and Google Trends can also help you to find popular names, categories and trends to include in your tweets to grab attention.

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Tweet

a 140 character or less post or status update on Twitter.

Hashtag

you can use the # hashtag symbol in your tweet to draw attention to a specific part of your tweet. Hashtags are used as a way to categorize tweets. Users can search a hashtag to see all tweets that have used a certain hashtag. Hashtags are also used to identify trending topics.

Trending Topic

trends on twitter are determined by Twitter's algorithm as being the most popular subjects on Twitter at the moment, often including a # to identify it as a trend.

Follower

another Twitter user who has followed you. Users may have to request and wait for your approval to follow you, depending on your privacy settings.

Following

the twitter users that you are following. You will see the tweets from those you are following in your twitter feed or timeline.

Mention

you can be mentioned by users and also mention others on Twitter if you include the @ symbol then the user's name in your tweet.

Direct Message

Similar to a Facebook inbox message, these tweets are also 140 characters and are private between the users included.

Retweet

if you see a tweet you like, you can re-post and display it on your twitter profile. Other users can also retweet a tweet to you.

Favourite

If you like a tweet, but you don't want to retweet it, you can select the yellow star next to the tweet to mark it as one of your favourites, and it will appear in your favourited tweets section on your twitter profile.

Reply

you can reply to another user's tweet by selecting "reply" next to the tweet in your timeline.

Interactions

In the Connect tab you will see if others have retweeted, favourited or replied to your tweets.

Discover

the discover tab is where you find stories, other users' activity, other people to follow and browse categories of twitter accounts.

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Why should your business be on Pinterest?

Pinterest is currently the fastest growing site ever.ⁱ With 10.4 million users as of February 2012ⁱⁱ, and over **4 million unique visitors daily**ⁱⁱⁱ, Pinterest has created an opportunity for businesses to reach a large audience through “pinning” visuals related to a business. If your business relies on high volumes of website traffic to increase conversions, Pinterest can help to increase links and referral traffic to your site when visitors pin images from your site onto pinboards. Currently, **83% of Pinterest users are females** ages 18-34, so it's particularly essential to be on Pinterest if your business caters to these women.^{iv}

Tips for success

- Add the Pin-it button to your website! Then monitor what's working and what's not with your analytics
- Logging into Pinterest via a FB or Twitter profile allows you to automatically post your pins to these platforms for a larger audience to see (but you still can't connect Pinterest to your businesses FB page)
- To increase your followers, follow users that you would like to see following you back
- Don't feel limited by the visual nature of Pinterest. Think outside the box when determining your marketing strategy. Opportunities for branding alone are endless!
- Pin as often as possible and provide brief descriptions of images to give your followers more info

i. <http://www.talenthq.com/2012/05/the-latest-social-media-stats-for-2012/>

ii. / vi. <http://www.hubspot.com/google-plus-vs-pinterest-battle/>

iii. <http://www.brandignity.com/2012/05/how-many-people-use-pinterest/>

iv. / v. / vii. <http://socialfresh.com/pinterest-infographic/>

When should you post?

A recent study found that the best times to pin are **between 2 and 4pm (EST)** and **between 8pm and 1am**.^v



What should you post?

Most pins are related to design, fashion and décor, so if you're in the fashion or retail industry post images of your products to maximize leads from Pinterest.^{vi} For other B2C and B2B companies, post images of new products, services if possible, promotions, hold a contest, post infographics, staff pictures, or stimulate visual conversations with your followers by asking a question at the top of a pinboard. Ask, “What's your favourite product of ours?” and have your followers pin the images of their favourite products. Pins that include a call-to-action have seen an **80% increase in engagement**; add “buy yours here!” under the pinned image along with the link to drive traffic directly to the product's page on your site. Tutorials, DIY and recipe pins have seen a **42% higher click through rate**, and pins related to trending topics have seen a **94% increase in click through rate**.^{vii}

Tools to help



PinReach is a free analytics app that provides insight on the activity to your Pinterest profile.



Pinerly provides a number of tools that help to ensure you're posting great content, following the right people, and track your analytics for your Pinterest campaigns.

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Pin

a pin is an image that is added to Pinterest. Typically the image is linked to an external website from which the image is sourced, however images can also be uploaded from a device.

Pinning

Pinning is the act of either uploading an image from your device or selecting “pin it” from the pin it button you’ve installed on your browser’s toolbar.

Repin

a repin is a pin that you saw on someone else’s board on Pinterest, and you’ve decided to move or curate it onto one of your own boards.

Like

If you select “like” a pin, it will be maintained in the “Likes” section of your profile, and is not shared with your followers unless they check out your Liked pins directly from your Pinterest profile.

Comment

you can leave a comment on any pinned image that you come across on Pinterest.

Board

Where your pins are located. A collection of similarly themed images i.e. a board called “Home Décor.” st.

Pinterest Follower

A Pinterest follower is someone who has chosen to follow either a specific board(s) or all of your boards.

Mentions

you can mention a Pinterest user in the comments of your pin, using the @ symbol and the name of the person you wish to mention like you would on Twitter.

Hashtag

Also like Twitter, you can add a hashtag in the comments of a pin to foster easy searching.

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Why should your business be on LinkedIn?

LinkedIn is the world's largest online professional network.

With **161,000,000 members worldwide**, LinkedIn provides a saturated market perfect for recruiters, marketers and businesses alike. In Canada alone there are over 5,000,000 LinkedIn users. LinkedIn members did nearly **4.2 billion professionally-oriented searches** in 2011, and B2B and B2C businesses have seen significant customer acquisition via LinkedIn (61% and 39% respectively).ⁱ LinkedIn provides the opportunity for businesses to connect and engage with consumers and business decision makers with similar professional interests.

Tips for success

- Having a completed profile provides you with a 40% greater chance for networking success.ⁱⁱ Ensure you complete your company overview, careers, and products & services pages with plenty of content, images, and rich media
- When you share an update, selecting the twitter box will link your Twitter account with your LinkedIn profile, so you can share your company's tweets in your LinkedIn status

i. <http://www.socialmagnets.net/linkedin-stats-and-uses-infographic/>

iii. <http://www.hubspot.com/eBooks/learning-linkedin-from-the-experts/>

When should you post?

Given the nature of LinkedIn, posting a status or sharing content at noon is a good way to catch professionals on lunch break. Thursday and Friday evenings tend to perform particularly well. Early evenings also perform well, as professionals may check LinkedIn when they commute or return home from work. All in all, posting consistent and relevant content is a good way to keep your connections engaged.



What should you post?

Posting articles, blog posts, recent speaking engagements, status updates and conferences attended/spoken at are all relevant content for your profile, and are sure to keep your connections engaged. For company pages, post services offered and career opportunities. Curate content: provide value to your connections by re-posting articles and news related to your industry. Check the Answers section to see currently open questions that people have asked, and respond to whatever you can. If your answer is rated as the "best answer" this will show up on your profile – strengthening your reputation and credibility.

Tools to help



"Swarm" app is a visualization of currently searched company's on LinkedIn that you can click and explore. See if your company or competitors have enough hype to be in Swarm.



LinkedIn Outlook Toolbar is a plugin that assists in growing your LinkedIn network. For example, it allows you to see when people you e-mail are not yet in your network.



Box.Net is a free storage app on LinkedIn that allows the upload of files to a profile for others to download (for your company page, think whitepapers or case studies to show your expertise!)

- Add links on your profile to all of your company's social platforms
- Set a custom public profile vanity URL to make it easier for people to find you
- Join industry groups and other companies' pages to stay in-the-know, increase your connections and visibility, and see what your competitors are doing



Improve Your Social Media Marketing

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